Adenomyosis

Understanding a common but often under-diagnosed cause of heavy, painful periods

❓ WHAT IS ADENOMYOSIS?

Adenomyosis occurs when the endometrial tissue (uterine lining) grows **into the muscular wall of the uterus** (myometrium). This causes the uterine muscle to thicken and can lead to debilitating symptoms.

- 🔬 Unlike endometriosis, adenomyosis stays **within the uterus**
- 👩 Most common in women age 40–50, but occurs at any age
- 🤰 Often associated with prior uterine surgery or childbirth
- 🔗 May co-exist with endometriosis and uterine fibroids
- 📊 Affects up to **20–35%** of women — often under-diagnosed

💡 **Many women live with adenomyosis for years before being diagnosed — your symptoms are real!**

🚨 SYMPTOMS TO KNOW

- 🩸 **Heavy menstrual bleeding** — soaking pads/tampons, passing clots
- 😣 **Severe, cramping pelvic pain** before and during periods
- 📅 Prolonged menstrual periods (>7 days)
- 🤰 Bloating and uterine enlargement ("bulky uterus")
- 💞 Pain during intercourse (dyspareunia)
- 😴 Chronic fatigue from anemia (iron deficiency)
- 🔁 Irregular or unpredictable bleeding

📋 Diagnosis

- Pelvic ultrasound — first-line imaging
- MRI — most accurate for diagnosis
- Definitive: **pathology from hysterectomy** specimen

💊 MEDICAL TREATMENTS

🔵 Hormonal IUD (Mirena®)
Levonorgestrel IUD — reduces bleeding significantly. Often first-line treatment.
Fertility-sparing

🔵 Combined Hormonal Contraceptives
Birth control pills, patch, or ring — regulate cycles, reduce pain and bleeding

🔵 Progestin-Only Therapy
Norethindrone, depot medroxyprogesterone — induces "pseudo-decidualization"

🔵 GnRH Agonists (Lupron, Elagolix/Orilissa)
Induces temporary menopause-like state — reduces uterine size. Short-term use.
⚠️ Bone loss risk

🔵 NSAIDs
Ibuprofen, naproxen — manage pain and reduce menstrual blood loss

🔧 SURGICAL & PROCEDURAL OPTIONS

- Minimally Invasive **Endometrial Ablation** — destroys the lining; reduces or stops bleeding. Only for women not planning future pregnancy.
- Minimally Invasive **Uterine Artery Embolization (UAE)** — cuts blood supply to affected tissue
- Image-Guided **Focused Ultrasound** — non-invasive ablation of affected tissue
- Definitive **Hysterectomy** — the only permanent cure. Recommended for women who have completed childbearing and have severe symptoms.

Treatment choice depends on: symptom severity, desire for future pregnancy, age, and response to prior treatments.

⚠️ **Untreated adenomyosis can cause anemia — iron supplementation may be needed**

💜 You Don't Have to Suffer Through Heavy, Painful Periods

Adenomyosis is a real medical condition — not "just bad cramps." Effective treatments exist that can dramatically improve your quality of life while preserving your fertility if desired. Together, we'll create a plan that fits your goals and lifestyle. Please don't hesitate to discuss your symptoms openly with us at every visit. 💪 — (281) 557-0300